Chapter 2: The Innocent Party

After convocation, I went right home to start setting up for the party I had planned. I initially didn't want a party, since I'm not one for celebration – or people, but the relentless hounding by both Noah and Dr. Browne finally convinced me to have a small one. I only invited four or five people – since I didn't have many people I *could* invite. You know, because of the whole nerd thing? Not to mention the years of lab work and research may have prepared me for my teaching career, but it didn't help me at all in the socialization department.

I invited Noah and Dr. Browne, of course. I couldn't forget them after all the love and support they've given me over the last ten years. Aside from them, I invited a few of the other candidates I started with, Maria, Braeden and Mitchell, who I'd also gotten close to, but not as close as I had with Noah – nobody could ever get that close to me – dare I say, even my parents. I invited them to convocation – because it was an important part of my life, and I wanted them there, but they told me they couldn't afford the flight across the country. When I offered to pay for half, they declined it, almost as if they didn't want to be the type to accept help from their child. They were almost mad at me for even asking.

They've never really supported my aspirations to go into the field of computer science or my desire to teach. They were more focused on the typical jobs that parents hope for – you know, the prestigious ones: doctor (not the type I have, but medicine) and lawyer. Though I was always interested in math and science, the one science I could never get into was biology, so becoming an MD was out of the question right from the beginning. Similarly, I was never interested in studying law or politics, though I did like filling out paperwork and executing a well-written contract. I know I'm weird – I've been made fun of for it, and by now, I've just accepted it and made it part of my identity. We're all different in our own way, right? Why not embrace it? Anyways, back to the party.

As I set up the dining table for the six of us, I heard a knock at the door, which was surprising, since the party didn't start for another couple of hours. None of the food I ordered had arrived yet, and the snack trays weren't due to be delivered for another hour. I walked over to the door to open it, and I saw Noah standing there carrying a large bag.

"Why are you here so early? You do know the party doesn't start for a while, right?" I asked, as Noah gave me the biggest hug I've ever experienced.

He laughed softly, and said "You're my best friend in the entire world – why would I not want to be early? 'Just means I can spend some more time with you before everyone else gets here, and you know I always love spending time with you."

"I guess that makes sense – but I still have no idea why you've stayed with me for all this time. We're polar opposites."

"All that knowledge and you still can't understand social cues? Well, you always say that opposites attract - right?" He laughed, and so did I. See what I mean about being made fun of for

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being weird? But when it came from Noah, I didn't mind as much – I knew he didn't mean it. Of course, there were times when he'd gone too far, and I always told him, but for the most part it was light-hearted. *Did he really make a science joke? Is he flirting with me? Does this mean he does feel the same way I do?* I thought. There's no way he actually paid attention to what I taught him while tutoring him for chemistry – the course he chose because, and I quote, so he could make some cool explosions – so he could stay on the hockey team. "Did you really just hit on me with a chemistry joke?" I asked him, mostly to annoy him, but also because I wanted to know the answer.
"I did," he replied with enthusiasm. "Did you not like it?"
"Well, I –" I stammered. I paused for a moment, trying to figure out what I felt. *Did I like it?*
"You know what, I did. It's not often someone flirts with me – let alone using science," I eventually managed to get out.

"There was also another reason I wanted to come a bit early. I wanted to say thanks for putting me in your speech – I had no idea I was that big of a friend to you. Thanks for bringing me up on the stage too – I have wanted to be up there for a long time, and who knows when – or if – I'll get a chance to get up there for real. I wish you would've told me – I would've worn something a bit better," he said, grasping on to my arms.
"Of course – you've been with me since we were in grade six – I couldn't leave you out of such an important moment in my life. You'll make it there eventually, and I'll be there when you do. I'll even be the one to put the hood over you if I can make it happen. I didn't tell you because I wanted to see your genuine reaction – and I didn't want you to pull any of your *stunts* up there," I responded.
"You know I wouldn't have—" he snapped, as I interrupted him.
"Oh, of course you would. Don't kid yourself. I know you more than you do sometimes," I snapped back, rolling my eyes, both of us laughing as I finished.
"I'll have to get you back for that, you know," he said, in a snarky tone.
"Of course – I'll be waiting," I responded, with just as much attitude.

"Anyways, I'd like to give you my gift early – you know, since I'm already here," he continued.
"Sure, better to do it now than with everyone here."
"Right – So… I went a bit overboard and got you a few different things. I hope you don't mind."
"Not at all – but you know you didn't have to do that."
"Yeah, but you mean the world to me. Why not go crazy?" He started saying as he reached into his bag, pulling some sort of controller for something out of it. "I was at the vintage store, and I saw this and thought of the both of us. It's a controller for one of those giant hockey scoreboards from Vancouver. I know you like tech stuff with a bunch of buttons and knobs and stuff on it – and I play hockey, so I thought it would be the perfect thing to represent the both of us. It's got a certificate of authenticity on the bottom too – so you know it's the real deal."

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I looked at the board with amazement while he was talking. In the middle of it, I could see all the labels for what each section and button is for, from changing the home and visiting team scores and shots, to adjusting the time, to – perhaps most important to 10-year-old me – sounding the horn. I saw a large number pad on one side, and the vintage logo for the Canucks on the other side.
"So, what do you think?" he asked, observing my intense interest in what he'd gotten for me.
"This is so cool!" I enthusiastically responded. Noah knew I didn't care for sports much, but I thought this truly did represent the combination of our interests. "You're right – it's a perfect representation of the both of us. I'm not sure where I'll end up putting it, but it can go on this shelf over here for now."
"I'm glad to see you like it. I wasn't sure you would because it's related to hockey. Here's an idea: do you have any space in your office? Could it go there?" he asked.
"It's from you. Of course I like it – hockey and all. I think that's a good idea – it'll be a reminder of our relationship, and it's definitely a conversation starter. The only problem is they haven't assigned me an office number yet, but when I get one, putting it in a prominent place will be my first priority."

He reached back into his bag and pulled out a large box, wrapped in paper with a pattern of graduation caps and diploma scrolls on it. "Come on – open it!" he said as I took it from his hands. I ripped open the wrapping like I was a kid again at Christmas, and inside I found what appeared to be a journalling set. On the box, it said *Journalling as Self-Care*. I could see the words "For Noobs!" written in sharpie next to the text, in Noah's handwriting. Through the plastic window on the box, I saw that the kit contained a plain, blue leather-skinned journal, a set of three pens, a mechanical pencil, and a reusable eraser.
"Journalling?" I asked, confused.
"I bought it for you to use to start taking research notes, but if you use it for something else, it's okay too. With all the trouble your students can give you, it wouldn't hurt to have an outlet to express your feelings. Well, besides me, of course – I'm still available." We both laughed as he finished that last sentence.

"One more thing—" he said as he reached into his bag. He pulled out what appeared to be another box, also wrapped in the same paper. "This one's… a bit sappy," he said as he handed it to me.
I ripped it open, and inside I found it wasn't a box, but a gift basket. Inside laid a stuffed husky dog wearing a graduation cap, a mug that said, "World's Best Friend", and a framed photo of the two of us from my graduation photoshoot a week ago.
"This is so thoughtful. I love it," I said as I moved closer to him and lightly hugged him. He squeezed me harder, so I squeezed him harder too.
I put the other gifts on the shelf, and we got to chatting and just casually hanging out, as we usually did when we were together.

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A while later, I heard another knock at the door. When I answered it, I saw both Braeden and Maria arriving together, wearing matching couples' outfits. "Cameron, my man!" Braeden exclaimed when he saw me. "Congrats on finishing – I always knew you'd be done first. We're not too far off though!" He gave me a hug – nothing in comparison to Noah's, but still affectionate enough to get the sincerity of his message across.
"Thanks, B! There's been times that I thought I wouldn't finish – and that defense, I'll tell you, it's nerve wracking. They grill you on so much in that room: from your experiment design, data collection methods, and analysis – not to mention the current literature in the field and how you're addressing a gap in current research. I thought I would never get out of there, but to hear them tell you you're finally done, it just hits different."
"I bet it does. We watched your defense online – you did a good job. Hopefully I'll be just as good when I do mine."
"I know you'll do great – don't put yourself down."
"Thanks, Cameron, I needed that," he said, smiling slightly. He came inside and made his way over to the living room to sit.

"Oh, Cameron, congratulations!" Maria screamed with excitement.
"Thanks Maria, it was a lot of work, but it finally paid off."
"I understand that – I do my defense next year, so hopefully it'll pay off for me too."
"It will – your research is sound based on the drafts I've read. You'll do fine."
"Here's to hoping – but I'm here for *you* tonight, so let's get the party started!"
She entered the house, sitting right beside Braeden on the couch, like she usually did. They've been almost as inseparable as Noah and me since they started dating in their second year. I wish I could have a relationship like theirs someday – but I'm hopeless, stuck on campus virtually all day, every day teaching and fulfilling my other obligations.

A while later, there was a third knock at the door. This time, it was the delivery service with the snack trays I ordered. I took the trays from the delivery person and made sure to tip him well. Right behind the delivery was Dr. Browne's all-too-familiar green car. I could spot that thing from the opposite end of the giant campus parking lot. As I saw her get out of it, I ran over to her in my driveway and gave her another hug. "I meant everything I said, you know."
"Of course, honey, I know you meant every word of it. I'm glad I could be that person for you. Are your parents coming tonight? I didn't see them during the ceremony."
"Nah, they told me they couldn't afford it, and when I asked if they wanted me to cover half, they insisted that they didn't want it."
"Oh, honey, I'm so sorry about that! Hopefully they make a visit soon."
"I'm used to it. They've basically ghosted me for the last five years. They haven't visited since the time you met them. But I know – at least I hope – they're proud."
"Regardless of what they think – I'm proud of you. Let's not think about the bad things but focus on the good things – we're here to celebrate your achievement. Oh, and I think what you did for

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your friend today was sweet – you don't see much of that these days. You two must have some relationship." She said as she went in and mingled with the others, as did I.

A short while later, I heard a knock at the door again. The only person not here yet was Mitchell, so I knew it was him before I even opened the door. As I opened the door, I saw him standing there. "Congrats guy! You worked hard for this," he said as I invited him in.
"Thanks Mitch, I appreciate it," I said, closing the door behind him as he walked into the living room and sat on one of the chairs I set out. He never was the social type – much like me, he's more into doing work than spending time with people, but he's comfortable with our small friend group. We didn't mind him either – he's helped all of us at some point in our research, and we helped him whenever he asked. Occasionally, he'd invite us to a movie or something small like that, but for the most part, he kept to himself.

Noah stood in the middle of the living room with his plate full of snacks from the trays, holding his glass full of wine and hitting it with the tiny fork he had for eating the pickles on his plate. "Hey, everyone!" he started yelling, to get everyone's attention. "I'd like to make a toast!" he said, moving around everyone so he could be right beside me. The room fell silent. "I would like to make a toast – to Cameron – congratulations on your degree! I've seen the amount of work you've poured into your research – and the amount of your soul you've dedicated to trying to figure out… whatever it is you were trying to figure out. You know I never really understood much of what you were talking about, but I'm grateful that I could be a part of this important part of your life. And the speech you made today was so moving. I especially like the part where you mentioned me!" he said, laughing. "In all seriousness, I appreciate what you did for me today, and as I congratulate you, I also want to thank you for being my friend for this long. I don't know where I'd be, or what I'd be doing with my life if you weren't in it." He hugged me again, just like he did when he arrived, before yelling "Cheers!" Everyone raised their glasses towards me, cheering after Noah's speech, and almost in unison, we all took a drink from our glasses.

Maria and Braeden were too busy turning my loveseat into their make out destination of the year to make a speech. Seeing them made me wish I had someone that would treat me like that and who would let me treat them like that. Mitchell wasn't one to make speeches, so I didn't even ask him to make one. This made Dr. Browne the next person to say anything. "Cameron, as you well know already, you're my first postgrad student. You're one of the first doctoral students to study here in the first place. Being with you on your journey has changed my life as much as it has yours. You've been as much of a mentor to me as I have to you. You've grown to be one of my best friends, and though I shouldn't say this, one of my favorite colleagues to work with. I know you'll do great things in the future, and I want you to know that I will do whatever it takes to be a part of it when you do."

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Hearing what everyone had to say made me feel extremely happy – something I'm not used to feeling around anyone. I wasn't used to being the center of attention – especially in a good instance. I guess it was my turn. Making my speech at convocation was stressful enough – and I had that one written down and rehearsed weeks in advance. Making a second, unplanned speech was even worse, but since everyone made an effort to make their own speeches, I figured it was only fair.
"Well, everyone here knows how I feel about being the center of attention, but hearing what nice things you've all said, it makes me feel something I haven't felt for quite a long time: like I belong. I haven't really belonged anywhere since I was in elementary school. Sure, I had Noah, but that was it. All through school – nobody other than Noah would even talk to me. Hearing everyone's kind words makes me feel like I finally found my niche. I appreciate you all."
Everyone clapped as I finished. They all rushed towards me to start a group hug. Usually, affection like that would make me uncomfortable, but for some reason, this time it didn't. Maybe I did finally find my niche.

I wandered around the room, mingling with everyone as much as I could. Some time later, Dr. Browne came to talk to me again. "I'm so sorry, honey, but I've got to go – I hope you don't mind!"
"Of course not – you just being here means a lot to me. Thank you for making the time, and I know I've said this a million times already, but I'm saying it once more because I truly do mean it – thank you for everything. I don't think I could have ever done any of this without you."
"Aw, honey," she started saying as a gentile smile came across her face. She put a hand on my shoulder and continued, "of course you could have! It's been in you since I taught you your first course when you started here! I always knew, I just had to get you to realize it." I hugged her one more time, almost in tears – not because of what she said. Well, it had something to do with it, but everyone being here for me, and saying such nice things, it made me emotional. I guess what she just said put me over the top. She left, waving at me as she exited the house and walked down the driveway.

Noah saw my tears, so he came over to check on me. "Hey – you alright?"
"Yeah," I answered him, wiping away tears. "I'm just not used to it. All this – and all these people coming to celebrate me. It just doesn't happen. I meant what I said, you know – you've been the only one to associate with me for most of my life."
"Shoot, dude. You know I'm here for you, right? If you need to talk, if you need a few minutes away from everyone, I'm here. I'll always be there for you."
"You always have been – and I appreciate it"
"Always happy to do it. You need some time away from everyone, just you and me?"
"I think I'd like that – can you just come sit outside with me for a bit?"
"Of course, whatever you need."

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We went outside and sat on the porch, Dr. Browne's words whirling around in my head – not just the ones she just said to me, but the ones she said as she got here. Noah held my hand and softly rubbed his thumb over my palm. Surprisingly, it calmed me down. I'm not sure if it was just because I was with him, or if it was the act of him rubbing my hand that helped – maybe both did. But right now, I just needed a break, and I'm thankful that he was there for me, like he always was. We sat there, in silence, while I took some deep breaths to help calm myself. We weren't out there long – only about fifteen minutes, but it helped me. When Noah could feel that I calmed myself, he asked "You ready to go back in, or do you need to sit out here for a bit longer? Either way, I'm staying with you all night."
I took one more deep breath, embracing the cool air of the evening – and Noah's presence – before telling him, "I think I'm good – and thanks again for being here."

We headed back into the house again and started mingling with Maria, Braeden and Mitchell. True to his words, Noah didn't leave my side.

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